

# Skinks and relatives

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|-------------|--------------|
| PHYLUM      | Chordata     |
| CLASS       | Reptilia     |
| ORDER       | Squamata     |
| SUBORDER    | Lacertilia   |
| SUPERFAMILY | Scincomorpha |
| FAMILIES    | 8            |
| SPECIES     | 2,477        |

**Skinks and their relatives** form the largest group of lizards. The skinks are mostly long and slender, and some species are without legs. Some have a method of reproduction that is unique among lizards, the females nourishing their developing young via a placenta. Skinks occur throughout the world but are most numerous in tropical and subtropical areas. Most live on the ground, often in leaf litter, but there are also arboreal and burrowing species. The other families in this group are the girdled and plated lizards, whiptails and tegus, and wall and night lizards. Like the skinks, most of these are ground-dwelling lizards.

## Anatomy

Skinks are typically elongated, with a slightly flattened body, a long tail, and a small, wedge-shaped head with small eyes. Burrowing species may have permanently fused, transparent eyelids, which allow them to see while burrowing, and no ear openings.

Some skinks have small legs or no legs at all, an adaptation to burrowing or living in dense vegetation, such as turf. When attacked, skinks readily discard their tail, which is sometimes brightly colored to deflect the attention of predators from their head and body.

Girdled and plated lizards have large, rectangular scales, each of which has a raised keel. This keel may be drawn out into a point in girdled lizards, especially on the scales behind the head and on the tail, which is used to form a barricade when the lizard is pursued into a burrow or crevice, or even as a weapon. When threatened by a predator, the armadillo lizard grasps its tail in its mouth, presenting the attacker with a spiky hoop that it cannot easily attack.

Whiptails and tegus have small scales, a slender body, a pointed snout, and long limbs, although this family also includes some legless forms. Tegus are generally larger than whiptails.

Wall and sand lizards are outwardly similar to whiptails, although they are found in parts of Europe, Asia, and Africa, whereas whiptails are restricted to the Americas. Many members of both families are brightly colored, and they are all prepared to sacrifice their tail if necessary.

## Reproduction

Skinks reproduce in various ways. Some species lay eggs, whereas others give birth to live young. In a few species, the developing embryo is nourished by the female via a primitive placenta. In others, the female lays eggs and guards them during incubation by coiling herself around them. She may also move the eggs if danger threatens. When the young hatch, the female licks them clean, and they may remain near her for the first few days.

Some of the relatives of skinks, notably a group of whiptails and another of wall lizards, are parthenogenetic—that is, they can reproduce without males. In these species, each young is an exact replica (clone) of the mother, and is therefore also female, producing eggs of its own as soon as it reaches maturity. Some species are entirely parthenogenetic; in others, there are some populations that include males and reproduce normally.

## FEEDING

*Most ground-living skinks are secretive animals that spend most of their time under the cover of leaf litter. They generally forage during daylight and take shelter under logs or stones at night. Small skinks feed on invertebrates. The larger species (including the major skink, shown here) also eat plant matter, and some may even eat rodents and birds.*

